

brought devastating fire down on an enemy battalion, which resulted in its surrender.

Grant married Julia Dent, the sister of a fellow West Pointer, in 1848, but after the War with Mexico was posted to California. He was so lonely that he resigned his commission in 1854 and returned east to join his family. His various business ventures did not prosper, and when Civil War broke out, Grant was working as a clerk in the family leather store in Illinois. He immediately re-enlisted, but was unable to get a commission again in the U.S. Army, and was appointed to command the 21st Illinois Infantry, a volunteer regiment.

He soon rose to the rank of brigadier general due to his previous military experience. Based in Tennessee, he led his men to an early victory at Belmont, and then took Forts Donelson and Henry, demanding unconditional surrender. At the time, other Union generals were suffering heavy defeats. Grant's successes led to his promotion to major general.

On April 6, 1862, when Grant and his forces were encamped at Shiloh on the Tennessee River, Confederate troops launched a surprise attack. The first day ended in near defeat for Grant, but the next day he launched a counterattack, and his troops prevailed, in the face of fierce Southern attacks, thanks to his determination and the sheer force of numbers. His troops suffered devastating losses in what was one of the bloodiest confrontations of the war to that point. This sparked demands for Grant's removal, but President Lincoln famously responded by saying, "I can't spare this man—he fights."

Grant's next major objective was Vicksburg, Mississippi. After a brilliant campaign, he took this Confederate stronghold in July 1863, freeing the Mississippi River to Union traffic and in effect dividing the Confederacy. Further successes in Tennessee, in particular the defeat of Braxton Bragg at Chattanooga later in the year, confirmed his abilities as a commander and his status as a national hero. Lincoln summoned him to Washington and on March 9, 1864, Grant was appointed general-in-chief of the Union armies.